

Using Environment Variables in a LavaLust Project

To securely configure your LavaLust project, especially when using an external database service such as **Aiven**, you should use environment variables instead of hardcoding database credentials directly in your configuration files.

Step 1: Open Your LavaLust Project Directory

Open your terminal or command prompt and navigate to your LavaLust project directory.

```
cd your-project-directory
```

Step 2: Create the `.env` File

Copy the `.env.example` file and create your actual `.env` file:

```
cp .env.example .env
```

This creates a `.env` file that will contain your application's environment-specific configuration.

Important: The `.env` file should not be committed to Git because it may contain sensitive information such as database passwords, API keys, and other credentials.

Step 3: Generate the Application Key

Run the LavaLust key-generation command:

```
php lava key:generate
```

This will generate the application key required by your LavaLust application and place it in the `.env` file.

Step 4: Configure the `.env` File

Open the newly created `.env` file and fill in the required configuration values.

For example, configure your database credentials:

```
DB_HOST=your-database-host  
DB_PORT=your-database-port
```

```
DB_DATABASE=your-database-name
DB_USERNAME=your-database-username
DB_PASSWORD=your-database-password
```

Replace the values with the actual credentials provided by your database service, such as **Aiven**.

You should also configure other required environment variables used by your application.

Step 5: Remove Hardcoded Credentials

Check your LavaLust configuration files, particularly:

```
config/database.php
```

If you previously entered database credentials directly into `config/database.php`, remove those hardcoded credentials.

Your application should instead retrieve the values from the `.env` file.

For example, **do not** permanently put credentials such as this directly in your configuration:

```
'hostname' => 'mysql.example.com',
'username' => 'myusername',
'password' => 'mypassword',
```

Instead, configure your application to use the corresponding environment variables.

This is important because database credentials should not be stored directly in your source code.

Step 6: Configure Environment Variables When Deploying

When you push your LavaLust project to GitHub, the `.env` file should normally **not be included** in the repository.

This means that when deploying your application to a hosting service such as **Render**, you need to provide the required environment variables through Render's **Environment Variables** settings.

For example:

```
DB_HOST
DB_PORT
DB_DATABASE
```

```
DB_USERNAME
DB_PASSWORD
```

Enter the corresponding values provided by your database service.

Alternative: Uploading the `.env` File

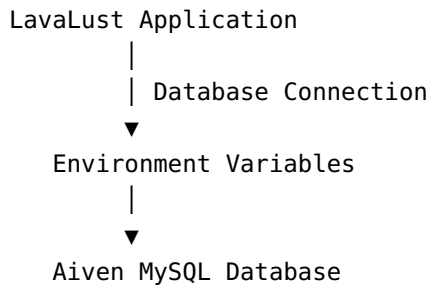
If your deployment environment allows it, you may also provide the `.env` file directly on the server.

However, make sure that the file is properly protected and is not publicly accessible.

Step 7: Connect LavaLust to Aiven

Once your `.env` file has been properly configured with the Aiven database credentials, LavaLust can use Aiven as its database service.

Your setup will look like this:



After completing the configuration, start or deploy your LavaLust application and verify that it can successfully connect to the Aiven database.

Important Security Reminder

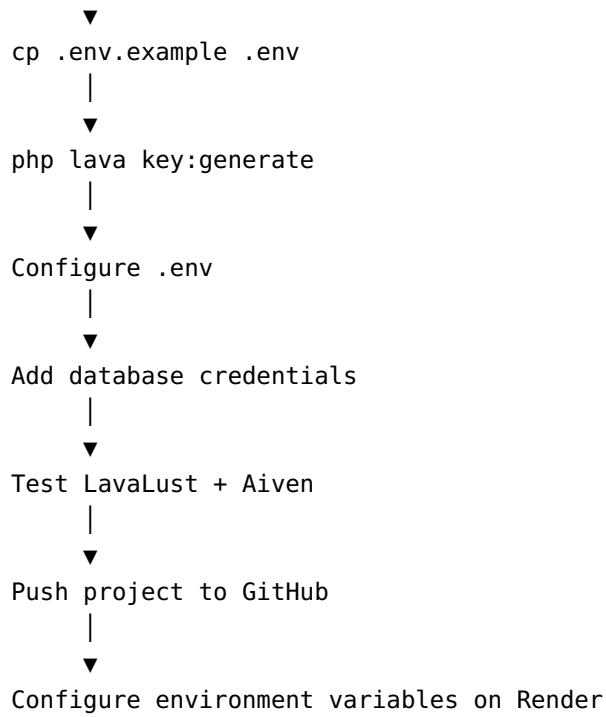
Never commit your `.env` file to GitHub.

Make sure `.env` is included in your `.gitignore` file:

```
.env
```

The recommended workflow is:

```
.env.example
|
```



Once these steps have been completed successfully, your **LavaLust application can use Aiven as its remote database service**, while keeping your database credentials separate from your source code.